

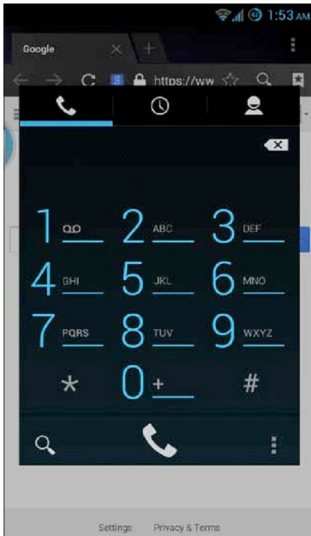


Figure 6: The HALO multi-tasking interface

there is a new notification from any user or system app. What's more, in conjunction with the expanded desktop mode, it may be used to completely replace the notification drawer. Whenever a notification pops up for a particular app, and the user clicks on this bubble to access that notification, the app opens up in its own overlay window, instead of replacing the current app. This is ideal when you need to perform a quick task that breaks the workflow of what you were previously doing. Need to take a quick look at that new email? Just click on the bubble and you can do so easily without having to navigate away from the previous app.

This feature is expected to see more active development in the coming months. If, however, you are not a fan of that ever-present bubble lurking in the corner of your screen, you can set it to disappear unless there is a new notification for you. On the other hand, if you like to use its functionality even more, you can pin multiple apps to it with the help of the 'HALO' companion app (Figure 7). These apps can then be accessed with the help

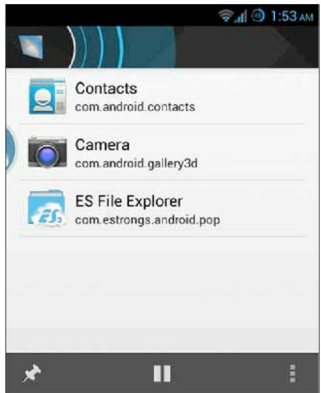


Figure 7: The HALO app lets you pin your favourite applications to the bubble

of the click-and-drag gesture to select the appropriate app. A blacklist or whitelist limits the number of apps that are allowed to display notifications from the HALO interface.

While these are certainly not all the features of Paranoid Android, they are what stand out. If you feel like supporting the developers of this ROM, go ahead and buy the Paranoid Android Preferences app from the Play Store, which provides some additional preferences and access to some cutting-edge beta features that the developers might release from time to time.

Android custom ROMs let you choose what you want and customise it even further in the way that you will never be able to in the stock ROMs provided by the manufacturers. One thing that needs to be kept in mind, though, is that if you break something, repairs can be costly and support is scarce, i.e., restricted to online forums. One needs to be aware of all the risks, and most importantly, take backups before trying out anything. This becomes all the more important, considering that you will be evaluating more frequent updates and, often, it will turn out that you are not satisfied with a feature that is still under development. **END** 

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